

LETTER FROM GEORGE LEAKE TO HENRY E. CLAY DESCRIBING
THE WRECK OF THE "GEORGETTE"

Perth
 6th August, 1877.

Dear Mr. Clay,

I have this morning received from you a note requesting me to give some particulars as to the circumstances connected with the wreck of the "Georgette" in order to correct some wild statements which have found their way into the English papers.

I shall therefore have much pleasure in telling you all I can remember of the affair.

The steamer left Fremantle early on the morning of the 29th of November and called in at Bunbury and the Vasse (Busselton) as was usual with her when making trips in that direction. All appeared to go well until about one o'clock in the morning of the 1st the vessel was found to be making water fast, this fact was kept from the passengers until about six o'clock by which time the water had so risen in the stoke hole as to have put the fires out so when I went on deck the sails were set and the vessels head turned towards land. As may be imagined there was some confusion, and orders had just been given to launch the life boats which was done and a few of the passengers put into her. We were at this time about 20 miles from land in sight of the Leeuwin sand patch. As soon as the life boat was launched preparations were made to launch another boat, but in lowering this one the after fall carried away and the boat was hanging with her stern in the water and might have got away altogether had not Willie Dempster without a moments hesitation swung himself into her and dropped astern of the steamer and commenced to bail her out. The life boat was then hauled up alongside again and filled for the most part with women and children, it was intended to fill the other boat also and allow them to tow astern until the last moment but in dropping the life boat astern through some carelessness she got under the counter of the steamer, was stove in and capsized, and all in her thrown into the water. Some three or four were pulled towards the vessel and others clung to the boat in which Willie Dempster was. Then it was that James Dempster, seeing his brother in need of assistance followed by the 2nd mate (Dewar) & cabin boy (Nunan), jumped overboard and swam to him, and helped him get those in the water on board the boat: Dewar and Nunan after doing all they could swam to the life boat and hung to it until they were picked up by the other boat which unable to return to the steamer shaped its course for land the steamer doing the same thing. Of those in the boat when it capsized seven were drowned namely two women and five children and no doubt more lives would have been lost had it not been for the timely assistance rendered and the presence of mind displayed by the Dempsters, Dewar and Nunan and taking into consideration the fact of the two Dempsters' having suffered from seasickness, the distance of the vessel from land at the time of the accident and altogether the risk they ran of their lives I think that their conduct cannot be too highly spoken of as also of the other two Dewar and Nunan.

After the boat parted company with us we kept on bailing until the vessel was run on shore in a convenient place, I say bailing because it was really the case as the water was passed up from below in anything capable of holding it and besides the pumps were choked and useless. As soon as the vessel struck preparations were made for landing those remaining on board about 50. And although we had a boat it was at once seen that there would be great difficulty in getting ashore through the surf although only

about 50 yards or less perhaps however the boat was launched and five of the crew got into her taking with them a line and made for shore but the first breakers that caught them capsized the boat and they with difficulty landed, after a great deal of difficulty another line was passed ashore and the boat hauled back again to the ship. ~~I do not~~ while Miss Grace Bussell and a half cast stockman who from a distance had seen the vessel unusually close to shore had ridden down to see what was the matter. The boat was then filled with the first lot and those on shore commenced to ~~have~~ ^{haul} ~~her~~ by means of the line they already had but as in the first case she was capsized in the surf although much nearer the land since they were able to pull her up with the rope, most of them were able to walk ashore but there were a few who needed assistance and seeing this both Miss Grace Bussell and the stockman rode in to help them and brought them out I do not think that either of the riders were in any danger at all for they did not get amongst the breakers as has been said in fact it would have been impossible either for a horse to keep its legs or a rider his seat in such a surf as was there running. I hope it will not be thought that there is any attempt to detract anything from the praise due to Miss Bussell indeed I consider she behaved admirably and had there been any necessity to go out further than she did, She would have attempted it without a moments hesitation but as I said it was impossible for a horse to stand in such a surf. Further I do not think it any compliment to the young lady to spread exaggerated accounts such as we have heard. I feel certain that Miss Grace Bussell did all in her power to render every assistance to those who needed it and no one could have done more than she did under the circumstances.

In my opinion the assistance rendered by the Dempsters Dewar and Nunan and the risk they ran cannot fairly be compared with Miss Bussell's pluck and readiness since the assistance they rendered and the risk they ran were so much the greater. Of course the fact of Miss Grace Bussell being a young girl adds very much to the lustre of what she did, but still that is no reason why the deeds of the others should not be viewed in their true light, or that what she did was of greater importance than what the others did.

All the passengers were landed in the same way as the first lot but with ^{less} inconvenience as the more they had at the rope the further they could ~~have~~ ^{haul} the boat up each time. All however shared alike in getting wet. When all were landed Miss Bussell rode home with the news and in the evening provisions were kindly sent down by Mr. Bussell from his station (8 miles away) and after a miserably cold night they all went on to the station, thence Mr. Bussell gave them all the assistance in his power to enable them to reach the Vasse and then they had little difficulty in going where they wished. I think I have now told you as much as is necessary but if I have omitted anything I shall be only too glad to answer any questions you may wish and if you like we can have a conversation on the subject; I quite agree with you in thinking these absurd reports should not go abroad without contradiction and in consequence you are at liberty to make what use you like of this information. From your note I conclude you have some intention of contradicting these statements yourself if so I hope this will be of assistance to you but of course you will not think of putting this I have written into print:-

Believe me

Yours very faithfully

George Leake

H.E. Clay Esq.,
Perth.

*Note in the transcript from which this
was typed -
I certify that this is a correct copy of a
letter I have in my possession.
S.G. Royce
15/12/1968*